

Lenovo IdeaPad S12

Lenovo's IdeaPad S12 with NVIDIA ION on hold pending Windows 7 debut

Apple to release tablet

Apple is rumoured to have been working on a tablet PC concept which they plan to release in 2010

Netbook test

platform is basically an Intel Atom processor paired with an NVIDIA chipset that has a powerful GeForce 9400 GPU onboard.

Every major manufacturer has jumped on the netbook bandwagon. Thus, in this article we bring you an extensive comparison of netbooks currently in the market, to help you pick the best one for your needs.

For the ones that did not make it - before starting with the test, we had contacted most of the manufacturers currently selling netbooks in India to send us a unit for review. A few manufacturers, namely Acer, HP, Dell and Lenovo apparently did not want their machines compared to those from other vendors and did not send us samples. These brands are therefore not a part of this test.

Samsung NC-310 A curvy netbook for Generation Y.

- Hip-design, easy to carry around, bright screen, good keyboard.
- Build quality not up to the mark, status LEDs not visible when lid closed, web cam didn't function in our test model, expensive.

This is Samsung's attempt at catching the hip-crowd's attention. The NC-310 has a curvy build throughout which make it easy to hold and carry around. It also makes the netbook look different. The uni-coloured exterior and black interior also add to the coolness. Some people might find the colours a bit tacky, but

it's a personal choice; either you like it or you don't. The materials used to build it don't give it a feeling of solidity. Not to say that it's poorly built, but we wouldn't dare to manhandle this one too much. We also wished the neck hinge was a bit stronger.

At 1.23 kg, it can be easily carried around. The glossy screen is adequately bright. Below it is the pebble-style keyboard. This offers an isolated key design; that is slight spacing between each square-shaped key. For typists used to standard keyboards, these could take some time to get used to. But it is worth persevering, and once familiarised, they are quite easy to type on. The only sore point is that the Page Up, Page Down and arrow keys are a bit too closely packed. This makes it too easy to hit the wrong key. The touch-pad also offers good accuracy.

Unfortunately, all the status LEDs are on the inside of the body, next to the touch-pad. Thus you can't see them when the lid is closed. For example, with a closed lid you wouldn't know if your netbook is running or not. The web cam on our unit simply refused to work despite repeated attempts. We therefore weren't able to gauge its quality. Also, it wasn't able to compute a graphics score in the PCMark05 test, thus not giving us a final PCMark score.

The speaker strip is placed above the keyboard on the lower body. It puts out pleasingly clear and unamplified audio. Although the maximum volume isn't very high.

Its 4-cell battery survived for two-and-a-half hours in our battery drain test. Thus it should give 3 to 3.5 hours of up-time under normal usage. The battery life can be termed as quite decent. It also fared reasonably well in our Wi-Fi test. For almost Rs. 28,000,

the NC-310 is fairly expensive. It would be a pretty decent netbook to recommend, had the price been a few thousand rupees lower.

Samsung NP-N120 A netbook that means business

- Bright screen, good Wi-fi performance, decent battery life.
- Pointy edges, the chrome sidings may not appeal to a few, slightly overpriced.

If the NC-310 was the netbook for the "young and the free", the N120 offers a rather cut-throat "meant for business" philosophy in terms of looks. It has a smooth black finish which is fortunately fingerprint proof. The edges are quite pointy and the chrome sidings may be a turn-off for some people. This netbook is quite thin. Even with a slightly bulging 6-cell battery, it weighs an acceptable 1.28 kilos. The build quality is a little better than the NC-310, and the same goes for the screen hinge.

On the inside we have a bright screen. The keyboard is of typical design (not like the NC-310's isolated keys). The keys are quite large and convenient to type on. However, like the NC-310 the direction keys and the Page up and down keys are small and squished together. This can be inconvenient from time to time. Unlike most netbooks that have speakers under their belly, here they are placed on either side of the screen. Thus they produce an unmuffled sound compared to most netbooks, which is adequately audible.

Like the NC-310, it failed on the graphics part of the PCMark05 test, thus failing to give

us a final score.

In the battery test, it survived a good 4 hours and 30 minutes. It also shined in our Wi-Fi tests, where it logged in faster data transfer rates even over longer distances from the router. The web cam delivered an average quality with a decent frame rate. The Samsung N120 is priced at Rs. 25,000. That's slightly overpriced; as competitive models with very similar specifications are usually around Rs. 3,500 bucks cheaper. We wouldn't mind recommending this netbook if it were competitively priced

Asus Eee PC 1008HA Slim wonder

- Ultra-thin and light, fabulous appeal, good keyboard, good battery life for a slim device, Wi-Fi 802.11n support.
- Screen brightness a bit low, non-removable battery, overpriced.

The 1008HA is part of Asus's "Seashell" line of cosmetically-enhanced netbooks, that have the same guts as the older versions. This Eee PC has an ultra-sleek design. It is just 18

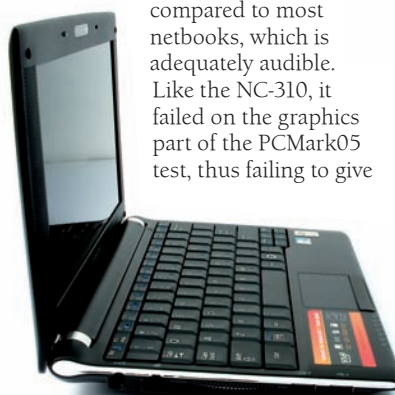


Asus Eee PC 1008HA

mm slim at its thinnest point. The beautifully-contoured body has a shell-like appearance and is covered in a piano black shade. The glossy body, as expected, is victim to fingerprints. At an ultra-light 1.1 kg, this is one of the lightest netbooks in this test. It can easily be slid away into the side-pocket of an overnighter bag. This is probably the first



Samsung NC-310



Samsung NP-N120